

for use at no cost or for an optional fee, but it does have one or more restricted usage rights, and hence cannot be free as such.

But then what's open source? Terming the free software movement anti-commercial, Eric S. Raymond and Bruce Perens started the Open Source Initiative (OSI) to bring practical benefits of freely available source code. It's a term which is now widely being used and gaining popularity across all sections of computer users. Open Source software is computer software that is available in source code form – and the license permits users to study, change, improve and at times also distribute the software. The obvious meaning of open source would perhaps be 'any software whose source code files are available' – but then this is not strictly the entire definition as given by the OSI. The huge number of licenses for Open source, and the ambiguous usage of the term itself makes it slightly difficult to make out the exact difference between free software and open source, but it more or less boils down to the philosophical values aspect of it. The term 'open source' is associated more with ideas that are based on the practical benefits of the software, such as making it more powerful or reliable. Whereas, free software focuses on the rights of the user to be able to improve or distribute the software, without any restrictions. So, no matter what kind of software it is, even if it is something that perhaps is designed to restrict a user's access to information, 'open source' would work towards making that program more powerful, contrary to 'free software' which would be against it for its basic obligation towards the rights of a user. From the four rules for a software to be termed free as mentioned above, it is clear that since access to the source code is required – free software has to be open source software as well. But, the reverse is not true in all the cases, as there are some licenses used with open source which do not necessarily meet all the requirements and hence not considered free. Software such as Firefox, VLC Media player, Blender, Audacity and also the GNU Linux kernel are all also open source and free software.

Tens of millions of people now use free software. Linus Torvalds put up the original Linux kernel for everyone to modify it back in 1991, and now it is a worldwide phenomenon which has constantly grown in competence and stature thanks to the contributions of millions of people worldwide. Free software developers work in virtual communities with little or zero face-to-face meetings with each other. They are all a part of a culture where recognition and respect is gained with how much you give/contribute towards the development of a common cause. Today, the open source movement is a reality, and we are witnessing it blossom. 